name from the temple town of Vaikom on the eastern banks of Vembanad Lake in central Travancore, its centre dominated by a long-established Shiva temple owned by a number of Nambudiri Brahmin families. Every road surrounding the temple grounds carried notice boards proclaiming the ban, with policemen on hand to enforce it.

After all efforts to get the ban lifted had failed, the Oxford-educated lawyer and Malayalam scholar Kavalam Pannikar, a Nair with a Nambudiri father, suggested that the Indian National Congress should show their interest, so as to make the issue a national rather than a local cause. Mahatma Gandhi became involved, and a date was fixed for what Gandhi termed a *satyagraha* or 'soul-force' demonstration in the form of a peaceful march by volunteers drawn from all communities.

On 30 March 1924 this first historic protest march duly took place, leading to the arrest and jailing of all the Ezhavas and Dalits who took part. More marches and more arrests followed, events becoming increasingly violent as Nairs and others weighed in to block the protesters. In April the Tamil reformer Periyar joined the marchers, together with his wife and followers, and they too were arrested and jailed. The elderly Narayana Guru also came to offer his support, only to quarrel with Gandhi over the issue of whether or not the scaling of the barricades erected by the police constituted an act of violence.

Mahatma Gandhi now appealed for all Nairs and Brahmins of goodwill to show their support, which led to a march of several thousand that entered Trivandrum on 12 November. A petition was then presented to the Queen Regent of Travancore asking for all the roads around Vaikom temple to be thrown open to all. Gandhi is said to have approached Rani Sethu Lakshmi Bayi directly to ask for her support but was rebuffed. He then spoke to her twelve-year-old son, the minor ruler of Travancore, Maharaja Chithira Thirunal Balarama Varma, and asked him if on attaining his majority